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ART

Of No Fixed Address

Jitish Kallat's *installation at London's Somerset House is intriguing, but hardly his best work*

At first glance, Somerset House is a typical neo-classical London pile, complete with Greek pillars and a large cobblestone courtyard. The history of the building and the site are a microcosm of the history of London itself: the original was finished around 1552 and housed Elizabeth the First when she was a princess; it was brought down in 1775, and the replacement was the first home of the Royal Academy of the Arts before the RA moved to its current location in Piccadilly; after being tenanted by a number of government offices, the North Wing became the home of the Courtauld Institute of Art and the House itself became a trust and re-purposed for public use, including art studios, music concerts, fashion events, public art installations and so on.

For his commission at the courtyard of Somerset House, Jitish Kallat has put up two intertwined waist-high spirals made of signs. The signage mimics the highway signs in the UK, with stern white lettering on a blue background and arrows and red stripes denying entry to various zones. Each sign has two or three place names and the distance in miles from the spot at which you are standing. The cities and towns range from ones in the immediate neighbourhood to the furthest points of the planet; after a while you understand that some of the place names are of stars, constellations and galaxies in the known universe, with the distance in millions of miles for the nearby ones and light years (LY) for the ones a bit further away. Some of the place names are of places that have already been submerged by rising sea levels, while others have a warning sign as indication of the imminent threat of submergence they face. The notes tell us that Kallat is playing with sacred geometry and alchemical diagrams as he has done with some of his other work.

While the piece is interesting and definitely worth visiting, none of the tactility and beauty of Kallat's best work is in evidence. Like so many other dry, cerebral conceptual artworks, this one becomes a one-liner: once you understand what the piece is trying to say—which is in the first five minutes—you're done; the piece yields nothing else, no sign of the struggle that might have gone into producing it, no layers or surprises. Given the combination of one of our most talented artists and a space that is so full of potential, this is a pity. ■

Ruchir Joshi

(Jitish Kallat's Whorled (Here After Here After Here) *is on display at Somerset House, London, till April 23)*



FOLIA SAREE, FROM OTHER COLLECTION, 2021, RAW MANGO

FASHION

Sari Not Sorry

The Offbeat Sari, an upcoming exhibition at the Design Museum, London, celebrates contemporary forms of the classic Indian drape

From runways to red carpets, the sari is enjoying an international moment. Most recently, saris were on display in their full splendour at the Oscars, where Guneet Monga, executive producer of *The Elephant Whisperers* (2022), received the Academy Award for Best Documentary Film in a pink Banarasi—a moment that will forever be etched in our memory. Female members of the *RRR* (2022) contingent too showed off the classic Indian drape, not to mention *All That Breathes* (2022) director Shaunak Sen's wife, who turned up in a hot pink sari.

The Design Museum, London's upcoming exhibition—*The Offbeat Sari*—which opens in May, could not have come at a more opportune time. Put together by Priya Khanchandani, the museum's head of curatorial, the exhibition will bring together saris from designers, wearers and craftspersons, while looking at contemporary "hybrid forms such as sari gowns and dresses, pre-draped saris and innovative materials such as steel". According to a report in *The Independent*, these will include the first sari ever donned at the Met Gala and Tarun Tahiliani's foil jersey sari made for Lady Gaga in 2010.

"Today, the sari in urban India manifests as a site for design innovation, an expression of identity, and a crafted object carrying layers of cultural meanings. The exhibition will unravel the sari as a metaphor for the complex definitions of India today," says the exhibition website.

The evening before the exhibition opens, Khanchandani will be in conversation with Indian designers Sanjay Garg, Sabyasachi Mukherjee and Rajesh Pratap Singh, discussing all things sari, from their earliest memories of the garment to its reinvention for a globalised market. There's also a 'Sari Draping' workshop by Mehala Ford on June 10. ■

Amit Dixit

(The Offbeat Sari will run from May 19 to September 17 at the Design Museum, London)